

Feminism

As a political movement feminism is based on the belief that the relationship between the sexes is one of inequality, with men dominating women. Feminism seeks to challenge and change this situation and bring an end to sexism, discrimination and injustices against women in all areas of society, from political institutions through to work, education and the family. Feminism contains different strands, reflecting differences of opinion over the causes of women's oppression and how to overcome it. 'Equal rights' feminism is the oldest tradition, which seeks to obtain the same political, legal and economic rights as men; Marxist/socialist feminism sees class as well as gender as a source of women's oppression; while Radical feminism seeks to redefine politics and abolish the patriarchy. Sometimes criticized for being white, middle-class and heterosexual, feminism has developed black women's groups and LGBT feminist strands. Feminism's impact on politics has been enormous, from achieving the vote to equal pay legislation and opposing female genital mutilation.

